

Chapter 28 - Caring

Following his shout, everyone's gazes once again gathered on the arena. In the center of the dome, smoke billowed, and several dark cracks had been split into the arena floor. The young woman who had just been struck down had somehow raised her head and was slowly rising, supporting herself with her long sword planted in the ground.

Her slender form appeared like a frail blade of grass in the thick smoke and strong wind, yet she stood strong and upright.

Chu Qingqiu's movement stopped. Her hand unconsciously returned to the table, then she slowly sat down.

Meanwhile, Mei Chengsi, who was disheveled and covered in ash, was hastily helped up by the Protector and Elder Jingshan. He wiped the tea water from his face, and being humiliated made him furious beyond measure: "Divine Venerable Chu Ling, I respect your cultivation and call you Divine Venerable, yet when I kindly advised you not to show favoritism to your disciple, you attacked me in front of everyone. We are both sect masters - what is the meaning of this behavior!"

As soon as he finished speaking, he heard Chu Qingqiu's voice, as if coming from beyond the heavens: "Sect Master Mei, though we are both sect masters, I am also someone who has cultivated a hundred years longer than you. Casually moving your hands and feet is disrespectful."

"Secondly, no matter what, this venerable is still a woman. Men and women should not have intimate contact¹. Your casual touching of this venerable is discourteous."

Mei Chengsi frowned upon hearing this: "But you injured someone..."

"Thirdly." Chu Qingqiu seemed not to have heard him at all and continued slowly, "Everyone knows this venerable cultivates the path of purity and most dislikes contact with others. Coming within half a foot of this venerable is an offense. Acting in urgency is merely normal self-defense."

As she spoke, she turned back and raised her hand to evaporate the water stains on her seat, calm as clouds and light as wind: "Sect Master Mei, please sit."

With these words, it was as if nothing had happened just now. Mei Chengsi wanted to get angry again, but was wary of Chu Qingqiu's strength. He held it in until his face was even redder than when he had just been scalded.

Elder Jingshan beside him wanted to help, but facing Chu Qingqiu, he dared not speak. So there was a moment of silence in the hall, until finally Mei Chengsi had no choice but to sit down heavily, wiping the remaining tea leaves from his face and forcing out a smile through gritted teeth.

And Chu Qingqiu's gaze had already completely focused on the arena.

At the same time, inside the huge hemispherical dome, the black mist before Ning Fuyi's eyes gradually dispersed, revealing Li Chao'an's face full of astonishment from the rolling thick smoke.

Although she dared not truly deliver a killing blow, with her previous strike, Ning Fuyi should have been unconscious long ago. Yet the young woman before her had not only remained conscious but had actually climbed back up.

Though that figure looked truly precarious, it still greatly surprised her.

The young woman's pale face was now smeared with several streaks of ash, her cheeks broken in two places, her arms covered with wounds. However, those eyes hidden beneath long lashes were like dark pools, reflecting the remaining lightning overhead.

"My turn," Ning Fuyi mouthed silently, then curved her lips in a smile. She gripped her long sword tightly, holding it horizontally before her face, murmuring something that caused the sword to slowly become tinged from tip to hilt with colorless power.

Li Chao'an was immediately terrified. She could feel that the originally meager immortal power of her opponent had surged greatly the moment she stood up. Though it still didn't match hers, it was ultimately unfathomable.

She no longer dared to be careless. Raising her precious sword, she once again gathered the power of thunder and lightning. Thunder rumbled overhead, thick clouds gathered densely, and lightning crackled within them. Then it formed an extremely fierce bolt of lightning as thick as a bowl, striking toward Ning Fuyi.

However, what should have been a sure hit was easily dodged by the young woman before her. Her speed had somehow increased several times. While dodging the lightning, she recited an incantation, and the sky above her head was suddenly filled with flames. Raging fire burned away the dark clouds, like a scalding canopy that covered the sky and earth, pressing down toward Li Chao'an with lightning speed.

It was exactly the same move as Liu Wenzhu had used that day. Li Chao'an hurriedly summoned a barrier to block the flames, the scorching breath nearly burning her eyelashes.

When the flames finally died out, Li Chao'an quickly blinked to moisten her dried eyeballs, looking at Ning Fuyi in shock.

"When did you learn fire-element spells?"

Ning Fuyi seemed not to hear her at all and suddenly spread her arms wide. Countless vines burst from the ground, quickly entangling Li Chao'an's feet. Li Chao'an hurriedly swung her precious sword to cut the vines, but didn't expect that at the same time a great wind arose, sand and dust blinding her eyes. Then her chest suddenly received a heavy blow. Sweetness surged in her throat as she fell backward and crashed into the dome.

This crash made the entire protective barrier tremble. The surrounding watching disciples were so frightened they all retreated, and the seated elders also suddenly stood up, looking at each other in dismay.

Chu Qingqiu's fingertips tightened on the table edge, but she didn't move.

"Isn't Ning Fuyi a water-element practitioner? How can she produce such raging flames and vines?" Elder Jingshan asked in surprise. "Sect Master, this matter is suspicious. Please halt the competition and investigate first."

"Elder Jingshan, we are selecting someone who can participate in the Zhaoyao Assembly². We have never limited practitioners to using only one type of spell. If she can master multiple spells, wouldn't that be a good thing?" Elder Yuanming said with a smile.

"Elder Yuanming knows what I mean. With her mere Mortal Realm cultivation, how can she use such difficult spells!" Elder Jingshan's beard bristled with anger. "Though this is an internal sect competition, we absolutely cannot allow cheating."

"The selection rules prohibit the use of Gu worms³, hidden weapons, forbidden techniques, spirit beasts, and forbid killing. Since Elder Pingyao has not detected any of these five behaviors, none count as violations." Elder Yuanming simply opened his fan and said.

Mei Chengsi seemed to want to make a move, but didn't get up. Instead, he placed his hand on his chin, watching with sinister eyes.

Meanwhile, Li Chao'an, battered by Ning Fuyi's attacks, felt anger surge in her heart. She suddenly leaped up from the dome, threw her precious sword into the air, formed seals with both hands at her chest, and the sword was immediately wrapped in crackling thunder and lightning, its entire body glowing brilliant blue.

More and more blue light wrapped around the sword, and the sword grew larger and larger. Only when the accumulated power reached its peak did it suddenly thrust toward Ning Fuyi's chest. This strike was made in lost rationality - ordinary opponents would either die or be crippled. Elder Pingyao, who had been watching the battle, saw the bad situation and suddenly reached out to intercept this strike, but her pupils slightly contracted and she temporarily stopped her movement.

She saw that Ning Fuyi had somehow also thrown out her long sword, learning her technique to gather thunder and lightning, but in addition to lightning there were also blazing flames. For a moment, the entire arena was filled with flashing lightning and dancing fire.

Before the surrounding spectators could react, blinding light filled the dome. The disciples all closed their eyes, and suddenly heard Li Chao'an scream. The moment the blinding light disappeared, everyone was dumbfounded.

In the thinning smoke, Ning Fuyi stood suspended in air, her eyes cold and cruel, looking down condescendingly at her opponent. Li Chao'an had already collapsed, foaming at the mouth, with that long sword pierced through her topknot. If the sword had gone down another half inch, it could have ended her life.

"Stop the competition!" Elder Pingyao shouted loudly. She leaped onto the arena and waved her hand to break the protective barrier, placing her hand on Li Chao'an's neck to check. Her expression was grim, but she also breathed a sigh of relief.

"Someone, take her for healing!" she said urgently. After someone carried the unconscious Li Chao'an away, she turned to face Ning Fuyi, her expression complex as she was about to scold her. But Ning Fuyi suddenly landed, barely supporting herself on both feet, swaying unsteadily.

The fatigue from excessive depletion of immortal power quickly caught up with her. Ning Fuyi's vision alternated between black and white, and Elder Pingyao's words seemed to come through several barriers, broken and unclear.

Finally, her knees went weak and she pitched forward. Elder Pingyao, who was mid-scolding, was startled again and took several steps forward to catch her, preventing her head from hitting the ground.

Ning Fuyi dreamed again. Each time she dreamed, the dreams were almost always of the mixed emotions of life before becoming a demon, or the pain of relatives and friends dying in front of her. But she couldn't dream much of the hundred years after becoming a demon, as if she had had a dream she knew about but couldn't remember clearly, passing by in confusion.

However, this dream was quickly interrupted by noise. Her face felt wave after wave of moisture. She turned her head to avoid that nimble tongue and opened her eyes.

The first thing she saw was a furry big head. The little white tiger was licking her face, covering it with saliva.

"Bai Lin." Ning Fuyi said hoarsely, reaching out to push Bai Lin aside and turning over to sit up.

The wounds on her body had disappeared, the grime had been cleaned away, and her dress was still that blue one, now neat and clean as new. Her body, which should have been depleted of immortal power, was the same as usual, with all internal injuries completely gone.

As soon as she stood up from the couch, she suddenly heard the sound of wind cutting through the air. Countless flying feathers connected into Flying Feather Rope⁴ around her, quickly binding her like a bundle and carrying her backward like a gust of wind.

Ning Fuyi gasped, her back hitting a redwood pillar, then she was tightly bound to it, only her fingers able to move.

A person appeared out of thin air before her - deep blue dress, tall and graceful figure, the white bone in her hand had transformed into a staff, gripped tightly in her palm. That peerless face was full of anger and ice-cold fury.

"Divine Venerable." Ning Fuyi was not surprised. From seeing the white tiger, she had known where she was, so she relaxed her body and slightly curved her lips.

"Don't call me Divine Venerable!" Chu Qingqiu said sternly, all kinds of emotions in her eyes transforming into angry flames. "What audacity you have, daring to use those crooked and evil ways in front of all the elders and disciples! And if you had truly injured a fellow disciple's life, when the four great sects unite to hold you accountable, even if Ning Changfeng were still alive, she couldn't protect you!"

"It's merely a technique to mobilize immortal power and overdraw cultivation. It's neither a forbidden technique nor a violation of rules. How is it crooked and evil?" Ning Fuyi said carelessly, not looking at Chu Qingqiu's face, her red lips slightly pursed.

This technique was something she had created in her previous life, so no one knew of it in this life, which allowed her to exploit the loophole of so-called "forbidden techniques."

"Divine Venerable, rest assured, I'm not that stupid. I never harmed her life. It's just that she tried to kill me, so I gave her a taste of her own medicine to teach her a lesson." Ning Fuyi grinned, but there was no smile in her eyes. "Could it be that Divine Venerable also thinks that Li Chao'an is precious - that her injuring me is just injuring a waste, while my injuring her would be destroying your Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate's genius."

As soon as she finished speaking, a gust of fierce wind came through the air. Originally aimed at her face, it somehow made an emergency turn and landed on her arm with a smack. Ning Fuyi's body tilted, and the struck area burned with pain.

Looking up again, those peach blossom eyes were now less than a foot away, anger making the corners red with blood, as if tears were about to fall.

"This venerable said you nearly hurt your own life!"

Footnotes:

1. **Men and women should not have intimate contact (男女授受不亲)** - A traditional Chinese Confucian principle emphasizing proper boundaries between unmarried men and women.
2. **Zhaoyao Assembly** - A major inter-sect gathering or competition mentioned in the story.
3. **Gu worms (蛊虫)** - Legendary venomous creatures used in Chinese folk magic and sorcery.
4. **Flying Feather Rope (飞羽索)** - A magical binding weapon made of connected feathers, as established in the story's terminology.

Author's Note: Yiyi: So you like my wife, is that it?